their nose to the grindstone. Ved Marwah had reason enough to pat himself on the back for the choice of officer he had made to the prime minister. Kiran, on her part, gives the entire credit to Ved Marwah who allowed the expression of leadership qualities and encouraged work based on integrity.

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The question of pending file work came up again when she took over charge of Tihar Jail in May 1993. There were 140 files concerning vigilance matters pending at HQ as also a large number of prison staff under suspension for the past six to eight years or even more. These cases mostly pertained to an attempted escape bid through a tunnel that was later discovered to be a very old and forgotten sewer. A large number of the jail staff was suspended pending enquiry and investigation. Many of them were not even on duty when the incident occurred but, regardless, they were also punished. She kept on hearing the bogey of 'tunnel case, tunnel case' whenever she took up the issue of the pending files and decided to attack the issue head-on. She remarked in Punjabi: '*Keda* tunnel case, *le ao to sahi, paddhien te sahi*' (what tunnel case, bring it to me so that I can at least read it). There she discovered that a Bakshi Commission had already looked into the matter and found no evidence of any mala fide intentions on the part of the suspended staff. With that as sufficient evidence, she cleared the mess in one stroke.

When queried, 'did you do it because you thought the staff would be grateful to you and work with you under a feeling of obligation?' she replied: 'The suspended staff was already on more than 75 per cent of the salary, so why should I continue to waste manpower which is being paid anyway – and for so long! I also did it on the individual merits of the case seen in the light of the Bakshi Commission Report. Remember, I was there to take decisions and not to postpone them. You see, as head of the department if I do not solve problems then I myself would become part of the problem.'

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The North District was one of the six police districts of Delhi, and Kiran was the DCP there in August 1986. This district was one of the largest in area terms, around 412 sq. km with a population of over 1,900,000 then. (Delhi is now divided into nine police districts.) There were 83 villages in this area that bordered the neighbouring state of Haryana. The district was (and continues to be) communally very sensitive and highly crime-infested. Dacoities, burglaries, pickpocketing and drug peddling were rampant when Kiran took charge of this district. In record time she made 1033 externment proceedings and placed all of them under rehabilitative surveillance. The heinous crime rate dropped rapidly with regular spot arrests and swift investigation. Community help again came to the fore with the residents very forthcoming with their assistance. Chowkidars (watchmen) of different localities would be called to the police station for a monthly parade conducted by the station house officer (SHO). They were briefed about the activities in their respective areas and given necessary information about notorious criminals of the area. The watchmen once again became an extension arm of the police force and were treated as such. This feature gave their morale a big boost and contributed greatly to their efficiency and discipline.

By sifting through the mass of statistical data, it was discovered that one particular region was contributing the maximum to the field of crime. This was known as the Yamuna Pushta slum cluster, with a population of around 125,000. The people there were victims of abject poverty and lacked even the basic amenities such as drinking water and domestic electricity. Drug peddling was rampant amongst these people and women played the more active role in this activity. Kiran held a public meeting in the area and informed the residents that no form of criminal activity would be tolerated by